

BALI

THE ISLAND

OF GODS

A six-minute journey into Indonesia's living history

DESTINATION STORY / INDONESIA 2026

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Where the sacred is everyday

Beautiful islands exist all over the world, but Bali combines landscape, history, art and spirituality in a way that feels entirely its own. Offerings made from flowers and palm leaves appear on sidewalks, temple steps, shop entrances and parked scooters. Incense drifts through the air. Ceremonies seem to happen almost daily.

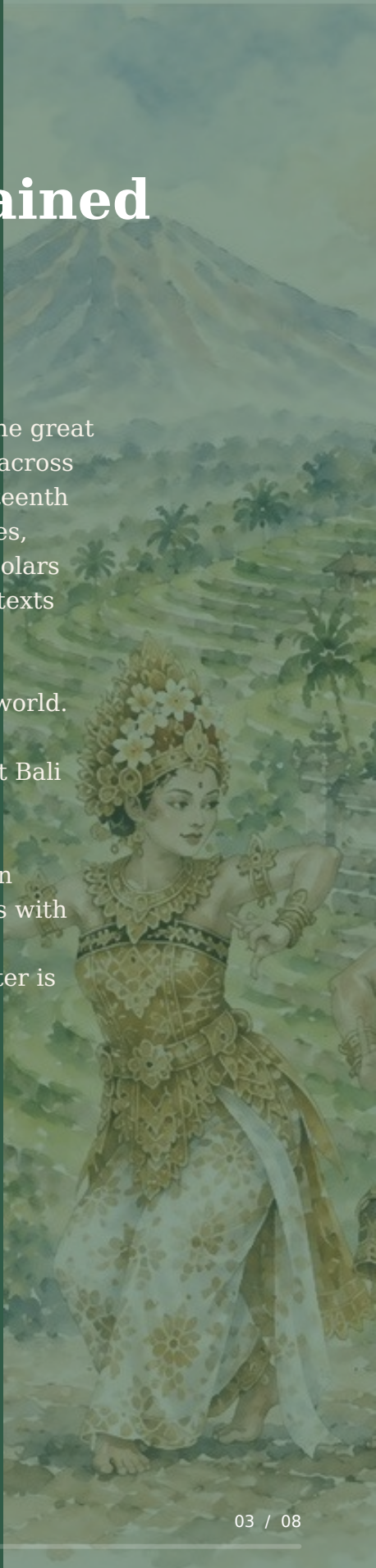
Bali often feels as though it remembers the importance of pausing. Religion is not limited to special occasions: it is woven into the architecture of homes, villages, hotels and businesses.

Visitors may first notice beaches and beauty. What stays with many of them is the sense that daily life still includes an active conversation with the unseen world.

AN ISLAND OF TEMPLES

Thousands from family shrines to village sanctuaries

How Bali remained Hindu



For centuries, Hindu and Buddhist kingdoms on Java influenced Bali. The great turning point came as Islam spread across much of Indonesia between the thirteenth and sixteenth centuries. Hindu nobles, priests, artists, craftspeople and scholars moved east to Bali, carrying sacred texts and traditions.

Bali became a guardian of an older world. Indonesia is now the largest Muslim-majority nation on Earth, yet Bali remains overwhelmingly Hindu.

Balinese Hinduism developed its own character, blending Indian traditions with ancestor worship, local belief and a profound respect for nature. Its center is not dogma alone, but balance.

The philosophy of balance

Tri Hita Karana teaches that well-being comes from harmony among people, nature and the spiritual world. This idea appears everywhere in Balinese life.

Every morning, millions of small offerings called canang sari are prepared from flowers, rice, leaves and incense. To a visitor they may look decorative; to the Balinese they are expressions of gratitude and respect.

Temples are equally present. Every village has them, most families have them, and hotels and businesses frequently include shrines. The sacred does not sit apart from ordinary life. It gives ordinary life its rhythm.

A DAILY CONVERSATION

canang sari — offerings of gratitude

Belonging before independence

Several generations often live within a shared family compound. Sleeping quarters, kitchens and gathering spaces surround a courtyard, alongside the family temple. Ancestors remain active members of family identity through offerings and ceremony.

That sense of connection extends to the village. Residents contribute time to religious festivals, communal work and shared responsibilities. Individual success is viewed alongside collective well-being.

Birth, adolescence, marriage, temple anniversaries, harvest and death all bring ritual. Tooth filing marks the transition to adulthood; cremation, or Ngaben, frees the soul to continue toward reincarnation. Ceremonies may hold grief, but they also carry music, color and movement.

Nyepi, the Day of Silence

The day before Nyepi is loud and spectacular. Giant demon figures called Ogoh-Ogoh move through the streets amid music, dancing and crowds. Then everything stops.

For twenty-four hours, roads empty, businesses close, lights dim and television broadcasts cease. Even Bali's international airport shuts down. The silence is intended for reflection, renewal and a fresh beginning.

Imagine New York, London, Paris or Singapore agreeing to close for a day of stillness. Bali manages it every year. In a world that rarely slows down, Nyepi feels increasingly radical - and increasingly wise.

A COMPLETE PAUSE

24 hours

the island falls silent

Ancient systems, modern Bali

Bali's rice terraces are not only beautiful. The Subak irrigation system has carried volcanic water through shared canals for more than a thousand years. Coordinated through water temples and farming communities, it embodies cooperation and respect for nature.

Ubud remains the island's cultural heart, where painters, dancers, musicians, woodcarvers and craftspeople work amid rice fields and jungle. More recently, yoga, meditation, wellness and digital work have joined the scene.

A temple procession, a surfer, a farmer and a laptop entrepreneur may all inhabit the same day. On paper, these worlds should clash. In Bali, they somehow coexist.

ONE LAST THOUGHT

Bali has embraced change without completely losing the traditions that give the island its soul.

LOOK CLOSER

At the offering placed before breakfast.

At water shared across generations.

At the quiet beneath the movement.

Welcome to the Island of Gods.

Adapted from the supplied destination brochure

INDONESIA 2026